

Ἑρμογένης ὁ Ταρσεύς

Hermogenes of Tarsus on the Ideas and Methods of Rhetoric

eul_aid: qng

Period: Ῥωμαϊκή [Roman](#)
Dialect: Ἀττικίζουσα τεχνική [Atticizing Technical](#)
Domain: Ῥητορική [Oratory](#)
Format: Λόγος [Oration](#)

Hermogenes of Tarsus was a Greek teacher of rhetoric who lived during the 2nd century CE, a period of renewed Greek cultural activity under Roman rule known as the Second Sophistic. Ancient sources record that he was a celebrated child prodigy, declaiming before the emperor Marcus Aurelius as a teenager. According to these accounts, his brilliant career as a performer ended prematurely due to a sudden loss of his ability while still a young man. He reportedly lived on for many years afterward, shifting his focus from performance to teaching and writing.

His lasting importance comes not from speeches, but from a series of influential technical handbooks on rhetoric written in Greek. His core surviving works include systematic treatises *On Issues*, concerning the bases of legal argument, *On Invention*, and his most famous work, *On Ideas*, which analyzes different styles of discourse. Another work, *Progymnasmata*, was attributed to him in later tradition, but modern scholars generally believe it was written by a different, later author.

Hermogenes is a seminal figure in the history of rhetoric. According to modern scholars, his works provided a comprehensive and systematic textbook for advanced study. His system for analyzing styles became a standard part of the curriculum. His impact as a theorist was profound, forming the foundation of rhetorical education in the Byzantine Empire for nearly a millennium, and his works were later studied in Renaissance Europe.

Works (6)

- [Περὶ εὐρέσεως](#) · [On Discovery](#) · 67 passages
- [Περὶ ἰδεῶν λόγου](#) · [On Ideas of Speech](#) · 107 passages
- [Περὶ μεθόδου δεινότητος](#) · [On the Method of Awesomeness](#) · 37 passages
- [Περὶ στάσεων](#) · [On the Stances](#) · 30 passages
- [Προγυμνάσματα](#) · [Preliminary Exercises](#) · 14 passages
- [Μαρτυρίαι](#) · [Testimonies](#) · 1 passages